

CRACK THE CODE

MASTERING CAMBRIDGE LETTER WRITING

Formal and Informal Directed Writing
Evaluation • Own Perspective • Register • Band 1 Control



WORKBOOK FOCUS

Decode the task, select ideas from both texts, evaluate them thoughtfully, control formal and informal register, and produce a focused 250–350 word response.

Assessment	Reading / Content	Quality of Writing
Directed Writing	10 marks	15 marks

Cambridge O Level English Language 1123
Student Revision Workbook • Teacher-Guided Practice

HOW TO USE THIS COMPACT WORKBOOK

Teach → demonstrate → guide → practise → assess

You will learn	You will practise
Formal and informal conventions	Four paired-text Cambridge-style tasks
Evaluation, development and synthesis	Two guided models and two reduced-support tasks
Own perspective and paragraph planning	Student and teacher assessment checklists
Vocabulary, register and accuracy	A timed final task

Contents

Pages	Section
2–3	Assessment, task decoding and seven-step method
3–4	Formal and informal layout, subject line, tone and register
4–5	Evaluation, own perspective, synthesis and planning
6–7	Vocabulary, sentence control, mistakes and editing
8–10	Sample 1: formal letter — mobile phones
11–12	Sample 2: informal letter — school trip abroad
13–14	Sample 3: formal letter — cars near schools
15–16	Sample 4: timed informal letter — tablets or textbooks
17	Marking, self-assessment and final Band 1 checklist

LEARNING TARGET

By the end, students should be able to explain why a paragraph earns marks—not merely copy a model.

1. WHAT CAMBRIDGE REWARDS

The 10 + 15 marking structure in student-friendly language

Reading / Content — 10	Quality of Writing — 15
Select a balanced range of relevant ideas from both texts.	Develop effective content and organise it purposefully.
Analyse, evaluate and develop facts, ideas and opinions.	Use varied, accurate sentence structures and precise vocabulary.
Use information for the exact purpose and audience.	Maintain the correct register for the reader and purpose.
Use mostly your own words; do not copy long stretches.	Control spelling, punctuation and grammar.

Level 5 targets

- Use approximately three or four well-chosen ideas from each text.
- Judge and develop the selected ideas instead of listing many points.
- Connect related ideas across the texts.
- Build a justified personal position from the stimulus.

Band	Reading / Content	Writing
Top	Wide selection; clear analysis, evaluation and development.	Complex, effective, well organised; wide range; consistent register; highly accurate.
Middle	Sufficient ideas with some development and focus.	Relevant and clear with some variety; errors do not seriously impede meaning.

Band	Reading / Content	Writing
Low	Few ideas; limited focus or development.	Simple, uneven and frequently inaccurate.

EXAMINER FOCUS

A polished letter cannot reach the highest overall mark if it ignores one text or only summarises. Strong source use must be matched by controlled writing.

2. DECODE THE TASK AND FOLLOW A METHOD

Every task contains a hidden writing plan

PAFTR	Question
Purpose	Am I advising, persuading, requesting, complaining or recommending?
Audience	Who will receive the letter?
Form	Formal or informal letter?
Topic	What exact issue must I judge?
Register	What relationship and level of formality are required?

The seven-step method

Step	Action
1	Read the situation and identify PAFTR.
2	Underline 3–4 useful ideas in each text.
3	Pair agreements, contrasts and competing priorities.
4	Evaluate importance, evidence, practicality, fairness or limitations.
5	Add a justified own perspective.
6	Plan 4–6 purposeful paragraphs.
7	Check word count, register, sentence boundaries and accuracy.

MEMORY LINE

Select → connect → judge → develop → decide → organise → check.

Thirty-second practice

TASK

Your local council may close a public park to build a car park. After reading two comments, write to the council.

Purpose	Audience	Form	Topic	Register
_____	_____	_____	_____	_____

3. FORMAL AND INFORMAL LETTERS

Conventions, subject line, layout and tone on one page

Feature	Formal	Informal
Audience	Principal, manager, council or official	Friend, cousin or close relative
Greeting	Dear Sir/Madam; Dear Principal; Dear Mr/Ms...	Dear Ali; Dear Sara; Dear Cousin
Subject line	Use a brief subject as the classroom convention unless the task gives another format.	Do not normally use a subject line.
Tone	Respectful, measured and purposeful	Warm, natural and personal

Contractions	Usually limited	Natural contractions are acceptable
Ending	Yours faithfully / Yours sincerely	Best wishes / Take care / Yours
Addresses	Not required unless instructed	Not required

Compact layouts

Formal letter	Informal letter
Dear Sir/Madam, Subject: Safer Roads Near Schools Purposeful opening Evaluate connected ideas Develop a solution / compromise Reasoned conclusion Yours faithfully, Name	Dear Sam, Warm opening linked to the situation Evaluate connected ideas naturally Give personal advice / experience Clear final recommendation Best wishes, Name

Too casual for formal	Controlled alternative	Natural informal alternative
This idea is rubbish.	This argument overlooks an important difficulty.	I can see why you like it, but...
You guys must fix it.	I urge the council to consider...	You should probably ask...
I totally disagree.	I remain unconvinced because...	I am not completely convinced because...

ACCURATE GUIDANCE

Cambridge does not award a separate mark for a subject line. It is a useful formal convention. Greeting, ending, tone and register contribute to the overall suitability of the response. Informal does not mean careless.

4. EVALUATION: THE CORE READING SKILL

Explain, develop, judge, qualify and conclude



SIR RUFUS TIP

Never stop after explaining a source point. Ask: How convincing is it? What has been overlooked? Under what condition would it be true? Is another idea more important?

Stage	Example
Point	A school trip abroad can make students independent.
Explanation / development	Students manage time, money and belongings; this may prepare them for later life.
Evaluation	This is convincing because ordinary lessons rarely provide genuine responsibility.
Limitation	However, a local residential trip could develop the same skill at a lower cost.
Judgement	Independence alone does not justify foreign travel unless it offers unique learning.

Evaluation move	Question / stem
Judge	How convincing or important is it? — “This is persuasive because...”
Challenge	What is missing? — “However, the writer overlooks...”
Prioritise	Which concern matters more? — “Although cost matters, safety outweighs it because...”
Condition	When would it work? — “This would be beneficial only if...”

Compromise

Can both priorities be protected? — “Rather than rejecting it, the school could...”

PARAGRAPH FORMULA

Source point → development → judgement → limitation or comparison → own conclusion.

5. OWN PERSPECTIVE AND SYNTHESIS

Your view should grow from the texts, not replace them

Weak own perspective

Strong own perspective

I agree with Text A.

Although overseas travel offers cultural exposure, it should be optional because cost affects families differently.

Phones should be allowed.

A controlled-use policy is preferable to a complete ban because it preserves learning and safety benefits while setting consequences for misuse.

Both texts are correct.

The two views identify different priorities; the strongest policy combines safety with realistic access.

Synthesis

WHAT IT MEANS

Bring related ideas from both texts into the same paragraph so that they agree, conflict or qualify one another.

Paragraph role

Plan

Opening

Purpose + issue + preliminary position

Body 1

Strong connected ideas from A and B + evaluation

Body 2

A second connected pair + development / limitation

Body 3

Own solution, condition or compromise

Conclusion

Final judgement + action or advice

PERSPECTIVE TEST

Can the reader explain not only what you believe, but why your conclusion follows from the two texts?

6. FUNCTIONAL VOCABULARY BANK

Choose language for a purpose; do not decorate the letter with forced words

Function	Formal expressions	Informal expressions
Opening	I am writing to express my views regarding...	You asked me what I thought about...
Introducing views	Supporters maintain that...	Some people think...
Evaluating	This is convincing / questionable because...	That makes sense, although...
Comparing	By contrast; nevertheless; a more significant concern is...	On the other hand; even so...
Recommending	I would respectfully suggest...	I think the best option is...
Concluding	I hope these views will be taken into consideration.	Let me know what you decide.

High-value evaluation words

Adjectives	Verbs
convincing, questionable, realistic, impractical, fair, one-sided, significant, limited, sustainable	acknowledges, assumes, overlooks, exaggerates, highlights, justifies, prioritises, underestimates

VOCABULARY RULE

Precise common vocabulary earns more than an ambitious word used inaccurately. Avoid memorised idioms in formal letters.

Register switch mini-practice

Basic idea	Formal alternative	Informal alternative
This is a bad idea.	This proposal may create serious difficulties.	I can see why this worries you.
You must stop it.	I urge you to reconsider this proposal.	You should probably think again.
This is a good idea.	This proposal has clear practical benefits.	This could work really well.
It is too expensive.	The cost may place an unfair burden on families.	It might cost families too much.
Everyone agrees.	Many people appear to support this view.	A lot of people seem to support it.

7. SENTENCE CONTROL, MISTAKES AND EDITING

Scaffolds for writing and a practical final check

Purpose	Useful frame
Qualify	Although this point is valid, it overlooks...
Develop	This would lead to... because...
Compare	While Text A emphasises..., Text B gives greater importance to...
Question evidence	This claim is less convincing because no evidence is provided.
State condition	The proposal would be beneficial only if...
Reach a judgement	On balance, ... outweighs ... because...

Frequent weakness	Repair
Separate summaries of Text A and Text B	Group ideas by issue and connect the texts.
Long copied phrases	Paraphrase accurately and briefly.
Opinion without evaluation	Link it to a source idea and judge it.
Memorised introduction	State the exact purpose and issue immediately.
Forced idioms or slang	Use natural, audience-appropriate language.
Very long sentences	Use full stops deliberately and vary structures.

Examination routine

Time	Action
5 minutes	Decode PAFTR; select and pair ideas; decide position.
30–32 minutes	Write 4–6 paragraphs; evaluate throughout; maintain register.
3–5 minutes	Check both texts, word count, subject choice, ending, sentence boundaries and SPaG.

THREE-PASS CHECK

1 Content: find one judgement in each main paragraph. 2 Register: remove anything too casual or artificial. 3 Accuracy: check full stops, agreement, tense, apostrophes and spelling.

Improve this weak evaluation	Your version
Foreign trips are expensive, but they are educational.	_____
The writer says tablets are modern. I agree.	_____

8. SAMPLE 1 — FORMAL LETTER

Fully guided: mobile phones at school

SCENARIO

Your principal is reviewing whether mobile phones should be allowed during the school day.

TEXT A — Hiba, student council president

As student council president, I believe mobile phones should be permitted at school under clear rules. They are valuable learning tools: students can check definitions, photograph homework instructions, use educational applications and research unfamiliar ideas within seconds. This is especially useful when computer rooms are occupied or when a class needs current information. Phones also provide reassurance. If transport is delayed or an after-school activity ends early, students can contact their families immediately. A complete ban would punish responsible students because a minority misuse their devices. Instead, phones could remain switched off in bags during explanations and assessments, then be used only when a teacher gives permission. Repeated misuse could lead to temporary confiscation. Schools are meant to prepare us for adult life, and adults must learn to manage technology responsibly rather than avoid it completely. A controlled-use policy would teach self-discipline while keeping the educational and safety benefits. It could also reduce the need for students to carry separate calculators, cameras and dictionaries. Teachers already manage other classroom resources, so a clear phone routine would be practical rather than disruptive. Parents could sign the policy so that expectations are understood at home as well as at school.

TEXT B — Mr Collins, teacher

I understand why students value their phones, but the classroom difficulties are often underestimated. Even when a device is silent, messages and social-media notifications divide attention. Teachers cannot easily know whether a student is researching a topic or communicating with friends, so valuable lesson time is lost through checking and arguments. Phones can also be used to photograph classmates without permission, spread hurtful material or share answers during tests. Not every family can afford an advanced device or generous data package; classroom phone use may therefore embarrass students and create an unfair advantage. Safety does not require unrestricted access throughout the day. The office can contact parents in an emergency, while students can collect their phones after lessons. Schools already provide books and computers for research, and teachers choose resources whose accuracy has been checked. For these reasons, phones should be stored securely from arrival until the end of the school day. Learning requires concentration, privacy and equal opportunity, and these priorities are more important than convenience. Furthermore, constant screen access can prevent students from developing patience and sustained attention. The school should invest in shared digital equipment that is monitored, filtered and available to everyone instead of depending on personal devices whose quality and content cannot be controlled consistently.

Combined stimulus: approximately 408 words.

SAMPLE 1 — QUESTION

Cambridge-style practice question

QUESTION 1

Your principal is considering whether mobile phones should be banned throughout the school day. You have read two opinions about the issue.

Write a letter to your principal.

In your letter you should:

- evaluate the ideas and opinions in both texts
- give your own views on the issue, based on what you have read in the texts

Base your letter on what you have read in both texts but be careful to use your own words.

Address both bullet points.

Begin your letter with “**Dear Principal,**” and supply a suitable ending.

Write about 250 to 350 words.

Up to 10 marks are available for content and up to 15 marks for quality of writing. [25]

FORMAT REMINDER

Use a concise subject line after the greeting, for example: “Subject: Controlled Use of Mobile Phones”.

Planning grid

Planning step	Notes
Text A strengths	Learning tools; family contact; responsibility
Text B concerns	Distraction; privacy; cheating; inequality
Evaluation	Benefits depend on permission and enforcement
My solution	Controlled use, shared rules and consequences

SAMPLE 1 — BAND 1 MODEL

Formal letter • synthesis • sustained evaluation

MODEL RESPONSE

Dear Principal,

Subject: Controlled Use of Mobile Phones

I am writing to recommend a controlled-use policy rather than a complete ban on mobile phones. Both the educational benefits and the genuine risks deserve consideration, but neither justifies an extreme approach.

Phones can provide quick access to dictionaries, educational applications and current information. This is particularly useful when computers are unavailable. However, the argument is convincing only when use is directed by a teacher; otherwise, research can easily become messaging, gaming or copying unreliable material. Devices should therefore remain switched off and stored unless a teacher authorises them for a specific task.

The safety argument is also important. Students may need to contact their families when transport or activities change. Nevertheless, unrestricted access throughout every lesson is unnecessary because the school office can manage genuine emergencies. More seriously, cameras and messaging can be misused to invade privacy, spread hurtful content or share answers. These dangers deserve firm consequences, but responsible students should not lose a useful tool because of others' behaviour. Regular reminders and digital-citizenship lessons would make the rules educational rather than merely punitive.

A fair policy would allow temporary confiscation after misuse and require phones to be kept away during explanations and assessments. The school should also provide shared devices when phone-based activities are planned so that students without expensive phones or data are not disadvantaged.

On balance, controlled access offers the strongest solution: it protects concentration, privacy and fairness while teaching students to use technology responsibly. I hope this balanced policy will be considered.

Yours sincerely,
Amina Shah

Word count: 260 words.

Paragraph	Main achievement
1	States purpose and qualified position.
2	Evaluates educational and safety benefits.
3	Takes privacy, cheating and inequality seriously.
4	Develops a workable controlled-use policy.
5	Prioritises responsible management over a total ban.

MODEL STUDY

Underline one judgement, box one limitation and circle one formal phrase in each main paragraph.

WHY SAMPLE 1 WORKS

Read the response like an examiner

Reading / Content	Writing
Uses relevant points from both texts and does not simply list them.	Maintains respectful register and a clear formal structure.
Evaluates benefits as conditional rather than automatically valid.	Uses varied sentences and precise vocabulary.
Recognises serious concerns and proposes safeguards.	Paragraphs build logically towards the recommendation.
Own perspective is a practical compromise.	Opening, subject and ending suit the audience.

Student transformation task

ORIGINAL IDEA

A complete ban would punish responsible students because a minority misuse their devices.

Rewrite this idea from the teacher's perspective, then evaluate it from your own perspective.

Self-check	✓
I represented the teacher fairly.	☐
I added a clear judgement.	☐
I suggested a condition or consequence.	☐

9. SAMPLE 2 — INFORMAL LETTER

Partly guided: school trip abroad

SCENARIO

Your cousin's school is considering a seven-day educational trip to another country.

TEXT A — Abdul Ahad, student

Our seven-day visit to another country would offer learning that cannot be reproduced through a textbook. Students would practise another language, explore historic places and experience customs directly instead of simply reading about them. Travelling with classmates also develops independence: young people must manage time, belongings and a budget while following a demanding schedule. Shared challenges can strengthen friendships and improve teamwork. The school has negotiated a group price that includes accommodation, transport, meals and entrance fees, and parents may pay in monthly instalments. Teachers have prepared a detailed programme and will divide students into supervised groups. For many learners, this may be their only opportunity to travel abroad during their school years. The memories and confidence gained could remain with them long after the examinations are forgotten. Education should widen horizons, and a carefully organised international trip would do exactly that. Students would also learn to cope with unfamiliar food, transport and routines, which could make them more adaptable. Fundraising events and a limited number of bursaries could support families who need assistance, while pre-trip meetings would prepare parents and students for the responsibilities involved.

TEXT B — Muzammil, parent

The trip sounds impressive, but schools should consider whether it is fair and necessary. Even with instalments, the total cost remains high, and some families may borrow money because they do not want their children to feel excluded. Students can visit museums, environmental projects and historic sites within their own country for far less. A local residential visit could still build teamwork and independence without passports, long flights or major disruption to lessons. Safety is another concern. Teachers cannot watch every teenager continuously in an unfamiliar city, and a lost passport, illness or missed meeting point could become a serious problem. International flights also damage the environment, which conflicts with schools teaching students to behave responsibly. Meeting another culture can certainly broaden a young person's outlook, but an educational activity should be inclusive before it is impressive. Unless financial support is guaranteed and the overseas programme offers learning unavailable locally, the school should choose an affordable trip within the country. The advertised group price may still exclude spending money, travel documents and emergency costs. In addition, students who cannot attend may feel left behind academically or socially if the trip becomes the main topic of school life. A shorter exchange programme or online partnership could provide cultural contact more fairly.

Combined stimulus: approximately 396 words.

SAMPLE 2 — QUESTION

Cambridge-style practice question

QUESTION 1

Your cousin's school is considering organising a seven-day educational trip to another country. After reading two opinions, you decide to write to your cousin.

Write a letter to your cousin.

In your letter you should:

- evaluate the ideas and opinions in both texts
- give your own views on the issue, based on what you have read in the texts

Base your letter on what you have read in both texts but be careful to use your own words.

Address both bullet points.

Begin your letter with **"Dear Cousin,"** and supply a suitable ending.

Write about 250 to 350 words.

Up to 10 marks are available for content and up to 15 marks for quality of writing. [25]

FORMAT REMINDER

Do not use a subject line. Establish a warm, conversational relationship and maintain accurate informal register.

Planning grid

Planning step

Notes

Planning step	Notes
Educational value	Culture, language, independence
Concerns	Cost, fairness, safety, environment
Evaluation	Value depends on programme and financial support
Advice	Ask about full cost and unique learning

SAMPLE 2 — MODEL AND NOTES

Informal letter • balanced advice • no subject line

MODEL RESPONSE

Dear Cousin,

It was great to hear from you. I can understand why the overseas trip sounds exciting, but I think you should look beyond the photographs in the brochure before deciding.

The strongest argument in its favour is the chance to experience another culture directly. Speaking to local people and visiting historic places could teach you more than a textbook. Travelling with classmates might also build confidence because you would have to manage your time, money and belongings. However, this benefit depends on the programme: if students simply move from one tourist attraction to another, the trip may become an expensive holiday rather than meaningful education.

Cost worries me more. Paying in instalments does not make the trip affordable; it only spreads the pressure. No student should feel excluded or force a family to borrow money for a school activity. A local residential trip could still develop independence and teamwork, although it would not provide the same cultural exposure.

Safety and environmental concerns are also reasonable, but they can be reduced through careful supervision, insurance and a sensible itinerary. They do not automatically make foreign travel irresponsible. In my view, the school should organise the trip only if financial support is available and the activities offer learning that cannot be achieved locally. Otherwise, the fairer choice is a high-quality trip within the country.

Talk to your parents honestly about the cost and ask the school exactly what the programme includes. Whatever you decide, do not join merely because your friends are going.

Best wishes,
Rayan

Word count: 256 words.

Feature	Evidence
Informal relationship	Warm opening, direct advice and natural use of “you”.
Evaluation	Cultural value depends on the programme; instalments do not reduce total cost.
Balance	Acknowledges benefits without dismissing fairness, safety or environment.
Perspective	Conditional support rather than automatic acceptance or rejection.

COMPARE

How would the same advice change if it were addressed to the principal rather than a cousin?

10. SAMPLE 3 — FORMAL LETTER

Reduced support: cars near schools

SCENARIO

The local council is considering restrictions on private cars near schools at opening and closing times.

TEXT A — Dr Elena Morris, local doctor

As a doctor at the community clinic, I strongly support restricting private cars on roads immediately outside schools. At opening and closing times, engines remain running while children cross between parked vehicles. This increases air pollution precisely where young lungs are most vulnerable, and it reduces visibility for drivers and pedestrians. A short vehicle-free period would make the area calmer and safer. Families who live far away could use designated drop-off points a few minutes' walk from the gates, while buses and vehicles carrying people with disabilities could receive permits. The council could also improve pavements, crossings and cycle stands. Similar schemes encourage children to walk or cycle, adding healthy activity to the day and reducing congestion for nearby residents. Some inconvenience is unavoidable, but it is minor compared with the risk of a serious accident. The streets surrounding a school should protect children, not operate as a crowded car park. Evidence could be collected during a trial by measuring traffic speed, pollution levels and the number of pupils walking. If the scheme is monitored carefully, the council can correct problems rather than allowing fear of inconvenience to prevent a potentially life-saving improvement. Clear signs and trained wardens would help families adapt during the first weeks.

TEXT B — Farah Khan, parent

I am a working parent and believe a complete restriction would create new problems. Many families travel long distances before parents continue to workplaces in other parts of the city. A compulsory walk from a distant drop-off point may be difficult for very young children, those carrying heavy bags, or families travelling in extreme heat and rain. Surrounding streets could become more congested as drivers search for spaces, annoying residents and delaying emergency vehicles. Public transport is unreliable in our area, and cycling is unsafe because there are few protected lanes. Rather than banning cars, the council should employ crossing staff, enforce speed limits and prevent dangerous parking. Schools could stagger finishing times and encourage car-sharing. These measures would target irresponsible behaviour without punishing every family. Safer roads are essential, but a policy should reflect the actual transport choices available to parents instead of assuming that everyone lives nearby or can alter working hours. The council should first survey families and publish a traffic plan. Without consultation, a restriction may be ignored, unevenly enforced or blamed on schools. Better enforcement of existing rules could produce faster results at a lower cost. Any trial should include temporary permits for genuine needs and a clear appeals process.

Combined stimulus: approximately 411 words.

SAMPLE 3 — QUESTION

Cambridge-style practice question

QUESTION 1

The local council is considering restricting private cars on roads immediately outside schools at opening and closing times. You have read two local opinions.

Write a letter to the local council.

In your letter you should:

- evaluate the ideas and opinions in both texts
- give your own views on the issue, based on what you have read in the texts

Base your letter on what you have read in both texts but be careful to use your own words.

Address both bullet points.

Begin your letter with “Dear Sir/Madam,” and supply a suitable ending.

Write about 250 to 350 words.

Up to 10 marks are available for content and up to 15 marks for quality of writing. [25]

FORMAT REMINDER

Use a formal subject such as “Subject: Safer Traffic Arrangements Near Schools” and end with “Yours faithfully”.

Planning grid

Planning step	Notes
Safety / health	

Planning step	Notes
Parent concerns	_____
Compromise	_____
Evidence for trial	_____

SAMPLE 3 — MODEL PLUS INDEPENDENT ANALYSIS

Find the evaluation yourself

MODEL RESPONSE

Dear Sir/Madam,

Subject: Safer Traffic Arrangements Near Schools

I am writing to support limited vehicle restrictions outside schools, provided that the council also creates realistic alternatives for families who travel long distances.

The doctor's concern about safety is highly persuasive. Children crossing between parked cars are difficult to see, and an accident would be far more serious than a short walk from a designated drop-off point. Reducing idling vehicles would also improve air quality. Nevertheless, a restriction that merely pushes congestion into neighbouring streets would solve one problem by creating another.

Parents are right to highlight unreliable public transport, bad weather and the needs of young children or those with disabilities. These practical concerns should shape the scheme, but they do not justify allowing dangerous parking to continue. Permits for disability access, school buses and exceptional circumstances would protect those who genuinely need to approach the gate.

The most workable policy would introduce a vehicle-free zone for thirty minutes at the beginning and end of the school day. The council should establish supervised drop-off points, improve crossings and pavements, consult residents and enforce parking rules in surrounding roads. It should also publish maps and allow a short adjustment period before penalties begin. Staggered finishing times and car-sharing could further reduce pressure.

On balance, safety and health outweigh minor inconvenience, but the policy must be carefully planned rather than imposed as a simple ban. I urge the council to run a monitored trial and adjust it after gathering evidence from parents, schools and residents.

Yours faithfully,
Daniel Reed

Word count: 258 words.

Find and label	Evidence from the model
One prioritisation	_____
One limitation	_____
One developed solution	_____
One formal recommendation	_____

EXTENSION

Change the conclusion so that the writer opposes the restriction but still proposes two safety improvements.

11. SAMPLE 4 — TIMED ASSESSMENT

Independent task: tablets or textbooks

SCENARIO

Your friend's school is considering replacing printed textbooks with tablets.

TEXT A — Noah, student technology ambassador

Replacing printed textbooks with tablets would make schoolbags lighter and learning more flexible. One device could hold every subject book, dictionary and revision guide, so students would no longer carry several heavy volumes each day. Digital texts can be updated quickly, preventing classes from using outdated information. They may include search tools, audio, video, diagrams and adjustable text size, which can support different learners. Teachers could distribute worksheets instantly and students could store notes in organised folders rather than lose loose pages. Although tablets are expensive initially, the school would not need to replace damaged or revised textbooks so frequently. Devices are already part of modern workplaces and universities; learning to use them responsibly would prepare students for the future. With protective cases, filtered internet access and clear classroom rules, tablets could improve both access and engagement. Digital platforms could give teachers immediate feedback on quizzes and allow absent students to access materials from home. Schools might also reduce photocopying and paper storage. If devices are purchased in bulk and insured, long-term savings could eventually outweigh the initial expense. Students could also collaborate on shared documents, submit work without printing and receive accessibility support through text-to-speech or translation tools. These features may make lessons more inclusive for learners who struggle with conventional printed pages.

TEXT B — Ms Patel, librarian

Printed books remain dependable, affordable and easier to manage. A textbook does not need charging, a wireless connection or technical support, and one damaged book is cheaper to replace than a broken tablet. Screens can distract students with games and messages, while long periods of use may cause tired eyes and reduce concentration. Not every home has reliable internet, so digital homework could deepen inequality. Schools would also need to pay for licences, repairs, security systems and staff training; the first purchase price is only part of the cost. Printed pages allow students to annotate, compare sections and revise without notifications or battery anxiety. Technology can certainly support lessons, but it should supplement rather than replace books. A blended approach—shared tablets for selected activities alongside printed core texts—would provide useful digital features without making every lesson dependent on fragile equipment. Printed books can be lent for years and passed between siblings, while electronic licences may expire or restrict access. Devices also create privacy and cybersecurity responsibilities. Before replacing books, the school should run a trial, compare learning outcomes and calculate the full five-year cost. It must also guarantee offline access and provide printed alternatives for students who experience eye strain or learn more effectively from paper. Choice and reliability matter more than appearing technologically advanced.

Combined stimulus: approximately 431 words.

SAMPLE 4 — TIMED QUESTION

Cambridge-style practice question

QUESTION 1

Your friend's school is deciding whether to replace printed textbooks with tablets. After reading two opinions, you write a letter giving your advice.

Write a letter to your friend.

In your letter you should:

- evaluate the ideas and opinions in both texts
- give your own views on the issue, based on what you have read in the texts

Base your letter on what you have read in both texts but be careful to use your own words.

Address both bullet points.

Begin your letter with “Dear Sam,” and supply a suitable ending.

Write about 250 to 350 words.

Up to 10 marks are available for content and up to 15 marks for quality of writing. [25]

FORMAT REMINDER

This is an informal letter: do not add a subject line. Suggested timing: 5 minutes planning, 32 minutes writing and 3 minutes checking.

Planning grid

Planning step			Notes
Text A points			
Text B points			
Main evaluation			
My final advice			
Planning began	Writing began	Checking began	Finished

SAMPLE 4 — TEACHER KEY

Use only after the timed task

MODEL RESPONSE

Dear Sam,

Your school's plan sounds modern, but replacing every textbook with a tablet would be a much bigger change than simply making bags lighter.

Digital books certainly have useful features. Updated information, search tools, audio and adjustable text could support different learners, and carrying one device would be easier than carrying several heavy books. However, these advantages depend on reliable equipment and trained staff. A tablet with a flat battery or broken screen cannot help anyone, and the first purchase price is only the beginning once licences, repairs and security are included.

The librarian's concern about distraction is also convincing. Even filtered devices can tempt students away from the lesson, while long periods on screens may reduce concentration. Printed books are dependable and make it easy to compare pages or annotate without notifications. On the other hand, refusing digital resources completely would ignore the skills students will need in further education and employment.

I think the best solution is a blended system. Keep printed core textbooks for regular reading and revision, but provide shared tablets for research, multimedia activities and updated material. The school should also lend devices for homework when necessary so that students without reliable technology at home are not disadvantaged. Teachers would need training and a clear technical-support system before the trial begins.

So, I would not support replacing books entirely. Tablets should expand the ways students learn, not make every lesson dependent on batteries, networks and repairs. Tell your student council to ask for a trial before the school spends a fortune!

Take care,
Alex

Word count: 260 words.

Source ideas	Evaluation / development
Lighter bags, updates and accessibility	Benefits depend on reliable equipment and trained staff.
Cost, licences and repairs	The purchase price is only one part of the financial burden.
Distraction and screen fatigue	Printed books remain dependable for sustained study.
Future digital skills	Rejecting technology completely would also be short-sighted.
Inequality at home	A lending system and printed alternatives protect access.
Final perspective	A blended trial is stronger than total replacement.

12. MARKING AND REFLECTION

Use the official 10 + 15 structure

Reading / Content out of 10		Writing out of 15	
9–10: wide selection; clear evaluation and development		13–15: complex, well organised, precise, appropriate and highly accurate	
7–8: range; some evaluation; clear focus		10–12: developed, secure, effective and generally accurate	
5–6: sufficient ideas; some development		7–9: relevant, clear and generally suitable	
3–4: some points; occasional development		4–6: simple, uneven and frequently inaccurate	
1–2: few points; limited focus		1–3: very limited control	
Area	Mark	Strength	Next step
Reading / Content	___ / 10	_____	_____
Quality of Writing	___ / 15	_____	_____
Total	___ / 25	Overall: _____	

Student self-check

Criterion	Yes	Partly
Both texts are used.	☐	☐
Each main paragraph contains evaluation.	☐	☐
Own perspective is justified.	☐	☐
Register suits the reader.	☐	☐
Greeting, subject choice and ending are suitable.	☐	☐
The response is 250–350 words and has been checked.	☐	☐

My next target: _____

FINAL BAND 1 CHECKLIST

The page to read immediately before writing



SIR RUFUS FINAL TIP

Format is the frame; evaluation and control are the picture. Use both texts, judge their ideas and sound completely natural for the person receiving the letter.

Before writing	While writing	Before submitting
Decode PAFTR.	Group connected ideas.	Check both texts.
Select 3–4 ideas from each text.	Develop and evaluate—do not merely summarise.	Find one clear judgement in each main paragraph.
Decide your position and conditions.	Maintain formal or informal register.	Check greeting, subject choice and ending.
Plan 4–6 paragraphs.	Use precise vocabulary and varied sentences.	Check 250–350 words and sentence boundaries.

THE BAND 1 FORMULA

Wide selection + purposeful development + sustained evaluation + justified perspective + controlled register + accurate writing.